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Date: April 30, 2024
Re: Possible Avenues of Support for Afghan Women
Subject: Policy Recommendations to Improve the Quality of Life for Afghan Women

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The reassertion of power by the Taliban since 2021 has been marked by severe backsliding in terms of the rights that women are afforded in the country of Afghanistan. Engagement with local-level religious leaders by way of international institutions, as well as offering an international platform for Afghan women to highlight their plight can serve as a step toward positive change. Much to the detriment of the Afghan economy, women in Afghanistan have been barred from public sector employment, however there are some opportunities for international organizations to support the employment of Afghan women in the private sector. There are signs that limited investment in school infrastructure is still being allowed, which is an angle that education advocacy groups can use to promote the education of Afghan women. As a final point, the main focus should be on engaging with local-level leaders and institutions to promote the inclusion of women in all aspects of life in the country, as it would be a boon for the country as a whole.

BACKGROUND

Afghanistan's journey in terms of women's rights has been directly informed by its history of political turmoil and the Taliban's extremist interpretations of Islamic law, which has had a disproportionate negative effect on the female population in the country. Afghan women witnessed some advancements in gender equality during the mid-20th century, with increased government support for women's education and employment. These gains were drastically reversed following the Taliban's ascent to power in 1996. Under the Taliban's stringent governance approach based on a fundamentalist interpretation of Islamic Law, women were stripped of their rights to education, employment, and ability to freely participate in public life. The Taliban's policies during this era not only regressed women's rights but also Afghanistan's broader democratic and human rights developments, significantly contributing to the deterioration of the social and economic structure of the nation.¹

After the removal of the Taliban government in 2001, Afghanistan entered a period of social and economic recovery, marked by notable improvements in the level of women's participation in the economic and political spheres. Women's representation in the Afghan government reached 27% by 2021, and there was a marked increase in girls' enrollment in schools. These advancements were supported by international efforts and funding, creating a more inclusive legal and social framework within the country,

¹ Omirzhanov, Y., Ghyasi, M., & Bertayeva, B. (2023). Taliban's Misconception of Islamic Law in Treatment with Women Rights. *Saudi Journal of Humanities and Social Sciences*, 8(05), 122–131. <https://doi.org/10.36348/sjhss.2023.v08i05.004>

especially for the women of Afghanistan. However, the resurgence of the Taliban in 2021 following the withdrawal of international forces led to the rapid dismantling of these improvements.

The reinstatement of the Taliban's severe policies and their forceful imposition of fundamentalist Islamic Law has led to a stark exclusion of women from education and employment opportunities, mirroring in many ways the oppressive Taliban regime of the past. Recent studies have highlighted that such exclusion not only violates the individual rights of women, but also holds extremely negative consequences for the overall Afghan economy, as evidenced by lowered labor market participation. Heightened fertility rates among women deprived of education opportunities have been followed by the health consequences of the underfunded medical services of the country.² Overall, the intentional regression and restriction of women's rights poses a significant threat to both the immediate and long-term social and economic stability of Afghanistan.

Recommendation 1: Promoting Gender Equality in Afghanistan

Since the U.S. withdrawal and the Taliban takeover of government in Afghanistan in 2021, promoting gender equality presents significant challenges. This is primarily due to the Taliban's patriarchal ideology. International organizations can still play a major role in advocating for the rights of women in Afghanistan. Monitoring the status of gender equality in the country can be difficult under the Taliban regime. However, utilizing the correct strategies, international organizations can still make an impact through empowering women using a few strategies.

Cultural and Religious Engagement

Under the previous Afghan government, before the Taliban takeover in 2021, there was some success in engaging religious leaders at the local level. Religious leaders and institutions are highly trusted in Afghanistan. According to a poll conducted by the US Institute of peace, nearly 80 percent of Afghans of both genders stated that they have trust in religious leaders and institutions.³ With such a high amount of trust that is placed, engaging religious leaders in meaningful dialogue to promote gender equality could be effective, especially under Taliban rule. According to research, there are two primary features of successful engagement with religious leaders in Afghanistan—leaders must feel like they have a stake and benefit in promoting gender equality among local population. One is that religious leaders must have a “spirit of ownership/partnership in the program.”⁴ If they feel as if they have a stake and legitimate interest in promoting gender equality that would work in their benefit—they will be more willing to engage in constructive dialogue about the issue. This is when they become useful assets. Secondly, in Afghanistan, religious leaders must be educated on gender equality in the context of an Islamic moral framework that can speak to their personal morality.⁵ If they are informed on gender equality issues from sources they already understand and trust, they will not only be more willing to promote these ideas but better equipped to efficiently disseminate information among local populations.

² Noury, A. G., & Speciale, B. (2016). Social constraints and women's education: Evidence from Afghanistan under radical religious rule. *Journal of Comparative Economics*, 44(4), 821–841. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jce.2016.07.005>

³ Kakar, P. L. (2016, October 11). *Engaging Afghan religious leaders for women's rights*. United States Institute of Peace. <https://www.usip.org/publications/2014/06/engaging-afghan-religious-leaders-womens-rights>

⁴ See Footnote 3.

⁵ See Footnote 3.

Engaging religious leaders and organizations will be difficult for the Taliban to ignore and control, as they consider themselves to be a religious organization.

International Advocacy

International organizations should continue to engage in advocacy to provide global education on the current status of gender equality in Afghanistan in order to spur more support from the international community. It is very important that governments, human rights organizations, NGOs and others continue to work together to raise awareness around the world. The best way to do this is to provide a platform where Afghan women can speak on their situation directly to the world. This means not just making sure that Afghan women are talked about, but rather heard from directly.⁶ When their testimonies and voices can be heard by people around the world, this will make it easier for international organizations to exert pressure on the Taliban to respect the rights of women. These groups most likely have the most access currently in Afghanistan rather than national governments. Funding outreach programs that survey Afghan women and their feelings and experiences would be greatly beneficial to promoting gender equality. Funding events and programs to share these experiences with the rest of the world and especially national governments and the public at large can help spur public support for gender equality and the plight women currently face under Taliban rule. These efforts must especially be increased so that the Taliban are unable to control the narrative or cover up their abuses.

Education/Awareness

Another strategy international organizations can use to empower Women in Afghanistan is providing a general awareness to their struggles under Taliban rule. This can take many forms and must include men, women, religious leaders, and policymakers. Some concrete examples would be public awareness campaigns, especially on social media to help the public understand the dire circumstances women currently face under the Taliban. Additionally, conducting workshops and seminars to help researchers and advocates understand the complexities of Afghan society and providing concrete strategies to pressure the Taliban would also be helpful. It is important that international organizations continue to fight back against harmful gender norms and stereotypes. Raising awareness in the Islamic world specifically would be very useful. Appealing to religious motivations to educate Arab populations for example will provide more space to exert pressure on the Taliban from multiple avenues.

Additionally, policymakers in particular must be educated so that they can take concrete steps through national governments to support the women in Afghanistan. NGO's are most poised to do this as they are often viewed as unbiased and can exert domestic pressure on national governments to stay involved in women's issues in Afghanistan. As mentioned, it is important that the stories of Afghan women and girls are heard and these awareness campaigns can help to spread awareness quickly and effectively. If international organizations utilize social media in particular, the dissemination of information concerning gender equality in Afghanistan, there may be more room for pressure to be applied on the Taliban to respect the rights of women. This would be another way to spur public support.

⁶ Davidian, A. (n.d.). *Expert's take: Gender equality is critical for Afghanistan's future, long-term development, and sustained peace*. UN Women – Headquarters. <https://www.unwomen.org/en/news/stories/2021/10/experts-take-gender-equality-is-critical-for-the-afghanistans-future>

Recommendation 2: Investing in Private Businesses

The Taliban government has issued 140 decrees, with over 90 of them restricting the rights of women and girls.⁷ One of the largest restrictions faced by women in Afghanistan is their right to work. The Taliban government has banned women from working in the public sector, as well as in NGO offices. The exclusion of half the population from participating in the economy has decimated the quality of life in the country. However, despite these restrictions, there are still ways in which the International Rescue Committee can help.

While women are very restricted in the public sector, they are not faced with as many restrictions in the private sector. They may work for private businesses, as well as own them. While there are still many hurdles faced by private business owners, especially by women, this is an area that can be targeted with international aid to improve the lives of Afghans. The IRC can support women in Afghanistan both directly and indirectly through investment in and support for private businesses.

Incentivize Businesses and Provide Career Training

While supporting solely women-led businesses can have a great effect, incentivizing a multitude of private businesses to hire women expands the scale at which women can participate in the economy and provides a greater workforce for these businesses. This can be accomplished in industries that can hire women without breaking the many restrictions placed by the Taliban such as textiles, spices, and healthcare (with proper training). While there may not be significant restrictions on private businesses in regards to hiring women, there could still be some apprehension about involving women due to Taliban harassment. A potential solution to this problem could be to encourage flexible working arrangements wherever possible so that women may work from their homes. This would allow them to participate in the economy without breaking any of the laws, as well as providing a safer option for business owners. Businesses could additionally be incentivized to source their products from women or from businesses that involve women. This can be incentivized through access to finances, which will be discussed later.

Additionally, there is significant intersectionality between the restriction on education and the limitations of economic involvement. For example, women are not restricted from working in healthcare or nursing, but are not allowed to undergo the education that qualifies them to take those jobs. To help address those issues, the IRC can partner with local healthcare facilities to provide vocation-specific training for the job that the women will be doing. While there are obvious challenges associated with this jump from the sixth grade to vocational training, taking small steps to reinvolve women in the economy could open doors for larger-scale efforts.

Financial Support

Financing a business is another key hurdle that many businesses face, particularly those owned by women. An important factor in addressing these challenges could be to provide financial support or access to credit for these businesses. This can be done through microfinancing measures, small business grants, and risk-sharing to allow for local lending.

⁷ Admadi, B., & Sultan, H. (2023, April 22). Taking a terrible toll: The Taliban's education ban. United States Institute of Peace. <https://www.usip.org/publications/2023/04/taking-terrible-toll-talibans-education-ban>

While the UNDP is currently micro financing some 75,000 businesses with \$16 million per year, more can be done to assist these businesses to hopefully observe an even greater impact. According to a UNDP official, each woman-led business employs six other women and young people and feeds a household of ten. The 75,000 businesses that the UNDP has already provided aid to benefitted 4.5 million people with a cost of only \$42 per business monthly.

Limitations

The unpredictability of the Taliban regime can change the landscape of what can be done instantly, making some of these efforts risky to undertake without the needed stability to do them. This extends to the constantly changing nature of what the Taliban deems as appropriate for women to participate in. For example, the Taliban's targeting of beauty parlors in the summer of 2023 alone left 60,000 women out of a job. Additionally, due to the constant harassment from the Taliban religious police, many employers are replacing their female employees with men altogether, which presents another challenge.⁸ Limited access to the internet could provide a challenge in how services can be provided to business owners in Afghanistan, as well as how effectively these interventions can be monitored and evaluated. Finally, creating a stable supply chain for these businesses to operate smoothly could prove difficult due to the instability in the region.

Recommendation 3: Improving Accessibility to Education

Education in Afghanistan is currently in a dire state as new laws imposed by the Taliban government have severely restricted women and girls' right to have education like their male counterparts. Female students are banned from going into secondary schools and universities. There had been progress prior to the Taliban's rule, as about 3,816,793 girls were enrolled in primary and secondary schools, and more than 100,000 women were enrolled in universities.⁹ However, the new rules and regulations have set back this progress significantly. Thanks to further restrictions on women in the workforce, Afghanistan has essentially cut down its economy by half and the quality of life for its people has deteriorated. The importance of education cannot be overstated because it is one of the key solutions to improving these aforementioned problems. Women and girls deserve to gain back their rights to good, proper education. Even with the restrictions sanctioned against them, there are still ways that can support them to have education.

Investing in Education Infrastructures and Materials

It is reported that the US had contributed about \$1.3 billion in the education sector over the span of two decades during its occupation, but thanks to the recent developments, a lot of changes have been reversed.¹⁰ Many educational facilities in Afghanistan are deteriorating and some schools have been shut down completely. A lot of them have been converted into madrasas, which are aimed for boys and young

⁸ See Footnote 7.

⁹ See Footnote 7.

¹⁰ Special Inspector General for Afghanistan Reconstruction (SIGAR). (2023, October). Sigar 24-01-IP status of education in Afghanistan. <https://www.sigar.mil/pdf/evaluations/SIGAR-24-01-IP.pdf>

men only.¹¹ Nonetheless, earlier April of this year, the Taliban have finally allowed UNICEF to build a new school in the Surkh Murghab village, in central Afghanistan, which grants more than 1,200 children access to education.¹² Despite all the setbacks so far, this signals a potential for any NGOs that want to help invest in education infrastructures, which, aside from building new facilities and classrooms, can also include funding school supplies, textbooks and other needed resources.

Helping Rural and Remote Areas with Community-Based Education

There is a huge disparity between urban and rural areas when it comes to education accessibility. One reasonable, yet cost-effective, solution is promoting community-based education (CBE). The USAID used to implement the Partnership for Advancing Community-based Education in Afghanistan (PACE-A) for a period of five years, where local communities would provide space for the school setting and USAID would provide any necessary educational supplies. A study from 2009 found PACE-A to be relatively effective as it increased overall enrollment for students in formal schools by 42%, as well as their test scores by 1.2 standard deviations compared to those that did not enroll in this program.¹³ The results show that for every additional mile a school was from the students' homes, the enrollment rates would fall by 16% and test scores by 0.19 standard deviations.¹⁴ By bringing education directly to rural communities, CBE programs can mitigate a lot of the challenges that students have to face, such as long distances to walk and lack of school materials. Young Afghans living in remote areas, especially for girls who already lack any education in the first place, will benefit tremendously from this form of education.

Expanding Access to Online Education

Another simple solution is to provide additional learning courses and materials online for students. There is a vast array of online resources, from online classes and programs to educational videos or tutorials on various websites. Girls and women, who otherwise would not be allowed to study advanced topics since they could not go beyond primary school, could finally enjoy free access to these things without the risk of violating the current Taliban laws. Of course, this approach should not be treated as a permanent solution, but Afghan students need all the available resources they can get given their current situation.

Feasibility, Costs and Limitations

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¹¹ Dawi, A. (2024, March 14). Taliban expand madrasas, may never reopen girls' secondary schools. Voice of America. <https://www.voanews.com/a/taliban-expand-madrasas-may-never-reopen-girls-secondary-schools/7527909.html>

¹² Conley, B. (2024, April 8). Rural Villages Get First Schools. Alive-in. <https://www.alive-in.org/new-schools-are-not-enough/>

¹³ Burde, D., & Linden, L. L. (2013). Bringing education to Afghan girls: A randomized controlled trial of village-based schools. *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 5(3), 27–40. <https://doi.org/10.1257/app.5.3.27>

¹⁴ See Footnote 10.

things without the risk of violating the current Taliban laws. Of course, this approach should not be treated as a permanent solution, but Afghan students need all the available resources they can get given their current situation.

Recommendation 4: Utilizing Existing Communities and Local Leadership

The Taliban are grappling with the same administrative institutions as their predecessors, and are facing similar difficulties in managing.¹⁵ This means that, while another power change would be again gravely disruptive, aid must be provided in a way which avoids the liability of administrative turnover reversing any gains made. The Afghan state, even before the Taliban takeover, was gravely ill-equipped to facilitate substantial, long-lasting social reforms.¹⁶ The only women's schooling left after the takeover was secret schools existing mostly in rural Afghanistan.¹⁷ While coordination with the Taliban is necessary for many aspects of aid, the most robust and longest-standing institutions in Afghan society are those rural communities.

This also means particularized goals for aid, and specifically education. Aid for women's rights, education, and opportunities ought to be as closely aligned with the values of these communities as possible, which may prove difficult because, to a certain extent, the Taliban's attitude towards women reflects rural Pashtun Afghanistan's cultural norms. However, unless history breaks its habit, Afghanistan may see many more regimes in the years to come, and likely the only institutions which will fare in the near future will be those of the rural communities, even though they themselves are a barrier to nation-building projects in Afghanistan, past and present.¹⁸

CONCLUSION

The situation in Afghanistan as it stands today is dire for the women of the country, but a multifaceted approach that incorporates both the international community's resources with the local community's access to the population can be effective in pushing for positive change within the country. Maintaining access to local leaders is crucial, as they will be the key to implementing any improvements that the international community hopes to see for the women of Afghanistan. Efforts must be designed in such a way that they align with local values, but this does not mean that nothing can be done. Community based education for women appears to be the most promising approach, considering that internet access can be established much faster and cheaper than schools can be constructed. Any avenue of support that the international community can offer to Afghan women should be explored to the fullest extent possible.

¹⁵ Lieven, A. (2021). An Afghan tragedy: The Pashtuns, the Taliban and the State. *Survival*, 63(3), 7–36. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00396338.2021.1930403>

¹⁶ See Footnote 15.

¹⁷ Siddique, A. (2023, December 20). *Secret schools offer “a ray of hope” for rural Afghan girls*. RadioFreeEurope/RadioLiberty. <https://www.rferl.org/a/afghanistan-secret-schools-girls-education-taliban/32740641.html>

¹⁸ See Footnote 18.

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